ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Parallelism and balanced structures

Coordinate equivalent grammatical forms to create clarity, rhythm and rhetorical balance across complex lists and contrasts. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use parallelism and balanced structures to make relationships visible through repeated structure while avoiding false equivalence while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Coordinate equivalent grammatical forms to create clarity, rhythm and rhetorical balance across complex lists and contrasts.

MODEL

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.

matched clause/phrase form + matched function

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main parallelism and balanced structures patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses make relationships visible through repeated structure while avoiding false equivalence.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in speeches, essays, policy, legal drafting and persuasive prose.

Build meaning before form

Coordinate equivalent grammatical forms to create clarity, rhythm and rhetorical balance across complex lists and contrasts.

What parallelism and balanced structures communicates

Coordinate equivalent grammatical forms to create clarity, rhythm and rhetorical balance across complex lists and contrasts.

The central purpose is to make relationships visible through repeated structure while avoiding false equivalence. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.	three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status
The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.	two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight
We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.	a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: matched clause/phrase form + matched function. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Series parallelism	to/base forms or gerunds matched across list	The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.
Correlative balance	not only X but also Y with matched forms	The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.
Antithetical balance	matched clauses with contrasting lexis	We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status	Series parallelism
two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight	Correlative balance
a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape	Antithetical balance

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in speeches, essays, policy, legal drafting and persuasive prose. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02
matched clause/phrase form	matched function

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: make relationships visible through repeated structure while avoiding false equivalence.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits speeches, essays, policy, legal drafting and persuasive prose.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Series parallelism	to/base forms or gerunds matched across list	The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.
Correlative balance	not only X but also Y with matched forms	The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.
Antithetical balance	matched clauses with contrasting lexis	We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.	three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status
The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.	two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight
We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.	a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not mix infinitives, gerunds and finite clauses at the same list level without purpose.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Place not only immediately before the element contrasted with but also.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not force parallel form onto ideas that are not logically comparable.

01 · PRACTICE STAGE

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status?

OPTIONS The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability. · The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times. · We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight?

OPTIONS The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times. · We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses. · The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape?

OPTIONS We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses. · The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability. · The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status · two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight · a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight · a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape · three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape · three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status · two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Series parallelism / Correlative balance / Antithetical balance · Gap 2: three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status / two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight / a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Correlative balance / Antithetical balance / Series parallelism · Gap 2: two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight / a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape / three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Antithetical balance / Series parallelism / Correlative balance · Gap 2: a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape / three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status / two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status: _____. Choose the model that expresses two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight: _____. Choose the model that expresses a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape: _____. Choose the model built with to/base forms or gerunds matched across list: _____. Choose the model built with not only X but also Y with matched forms: _____. Choose the model built with matched clauses with contrasting lexis: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability. · The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times. · We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The policy aims to _____ and strengthen accountability. The reform _____ but also improved response times. We need _____; accountability, not excuses. State the full structural pattern for Series parallelism: _____. State the full structural pattern for Correlative balance: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The policy has three goals: less waste, wider access and stronger accountability.” using the Series parallelism pattern to express three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The reform reduced costs and improved response times.” using the Correlative balance pattern to express two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Evidence and accountability matter more than reassurance and excuses.” using the Antithetical balance pattern to express a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The policy has three goals: less waste, wider access and stronger accountability.” using the Series parallelism pattern to express three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Series parallelism to express three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Correlative balance to express two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Antithetical balance to express a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.

Series parallelism is the best match because three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status.

A2

The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.

Correlative balance is the best match because two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight.

A3

We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.

Antithetical balance is the best match because a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape.

A4

three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status

The Series parallelism pattern communicates three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status.

A5

two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight

The Correlative balance pattern communicates two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight.

A6

a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape

The Antithetical balance pattern communicates a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Series parallelism / three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status

The structure belongs to the Series parallelism pattern. Its communicative purpose is three coordinated goals with identical grammatical status.

B2

Correlative balance / two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight

The structure belongs to the Correlative balance pattern. Its communicative purpose is two outcomes presented with equal grammatical weight.

B3

Antithetical balance / a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape

The structure belongs to the Antithetical balance pattern. Its communicative purpose is a contrast sharpened by repeated grammatical shape.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.

Series parallelism: to/base forms or gerunds matched across list.

C2

The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.

Correlative balance: not only X but also Y with matched forms.

C3

We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.

Antithetical balance: matched clauses with contrasting lexis.

C4

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.

Series parallelism: to/base forms or gerunds matched across list.

C5

The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.

Correlative balance: not only X but also Y with matched forms.

C6

We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.

Antithetical balance: matched clauses with contrasting lexis.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

reduce waste, improve access

Series parallelism requires “reduce waste, improve access” in this model. to/base forms or gerunds matched across list.

D2

not only reduced costs

Correlative balance requires “not only reduced costs” in this model. not only X but also Y with matched forms.

D3

evidence, not reassurance

Antithetical balance requires “evidence, not reassurance” in this model. matched clauses with contrasting lexis.

D4

to/base forms or gerunds matched across list

Series parallelism is built as to/base forms or gerunds matched across list.

D5

not only X but also Y with matched forms

Correlative balance is built as not only X but also Y with matched forms.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.

to/base forms or gerunds matched across list. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended series parallelism effect.

E2

The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times.

not only X but also Y with matched forms. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended correlative balance effect.

E3

We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses.

matched clauses with contrasting lexis. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended antithetical balance effect.

E4

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability.

to/base forms or gerunds matched across list. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended series parallelism effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The policy aims to reduce waste, improve access and strengthen accountability. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses to/base forms or gerunds matched across list accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The reform not only reduced costs but also improved response times. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses not only X but also Y with matched forms accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

We need evidence, not reassurance; accountability, not excuses. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses matched clauses with contrasting lexis accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____